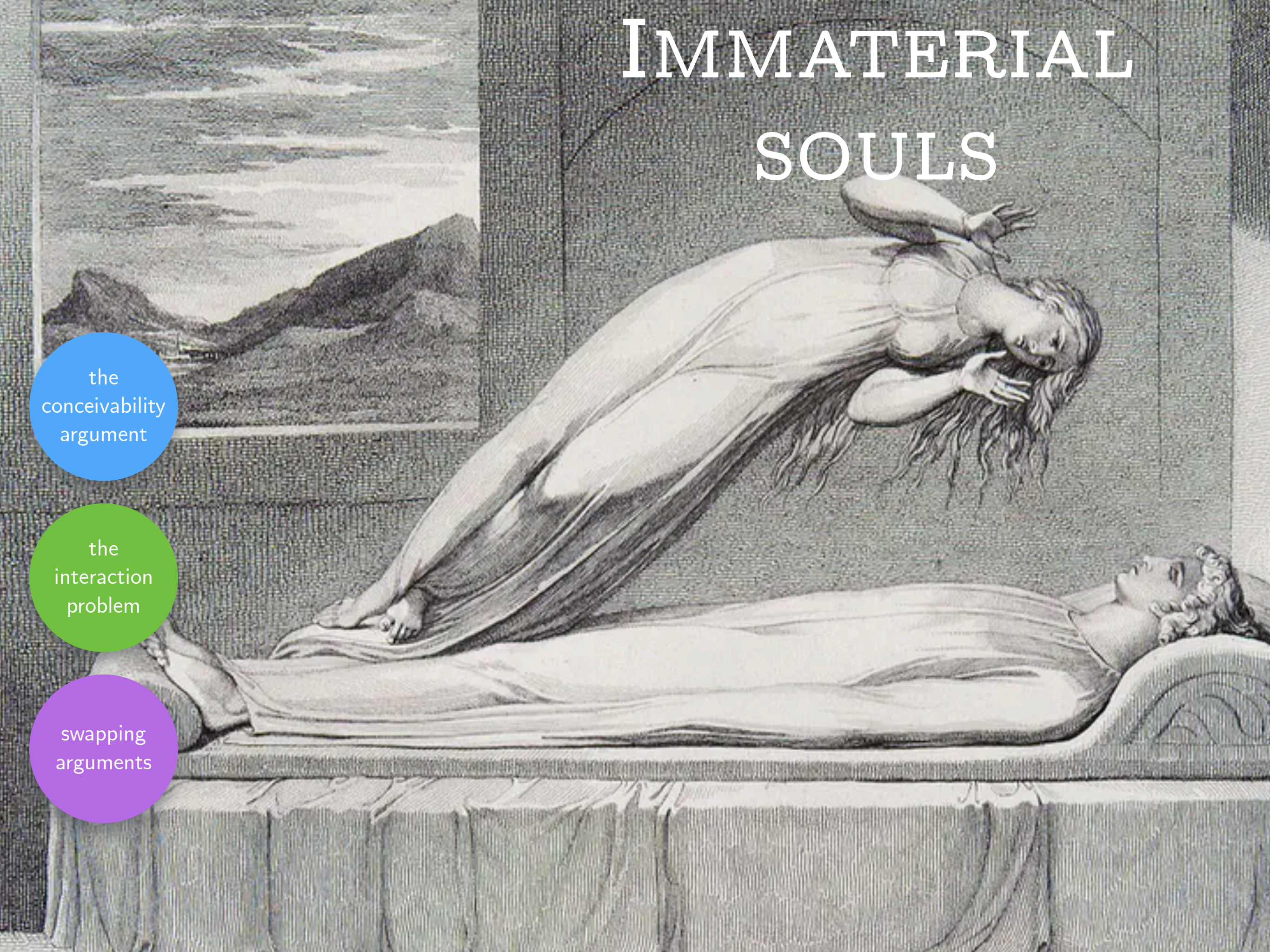


IMMATERIAL SOULS

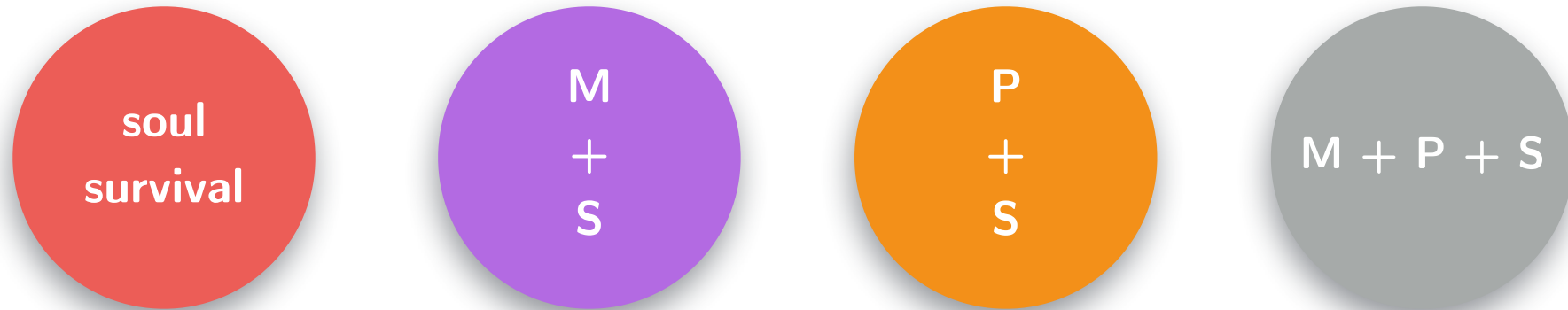
the
conceivability
argument

the
interaction
problem

swapping
arguments



Our topic today is the class of answers to the survival question which make reference to immaterial souls. There were four of these:



These theories are importantly different. But they have one thing in common: all are false if there are no such things as immaterial souls.

Last time we discussed some reasons to think that we should not believe in the existence of immaterial souls unless we have a good argument that they exist.

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THE EVIDENTIALIST ARGUMENT AGAINST BELIEF IN IMMATERIAL SOULS

1. We have no sensory experience of immaterial souls.
2. It is not self-evident that there are immaterial souls.
3. We have no good argument for the existence of immaterial souls.
4. If P is not self-evident and your senses don't tell you that P and you don't have a good argument for P, you should not believe P.

C. You should not believe in the existence of immaterial souls.
(1,2,3,4)

The argument we are going to look at turns on the idea that immaterial souls are needed to explain the nature of **consciousness**.

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Properties related to conscious experience include the property of feeling an itch or a pain, or the sensation of seeing red or hearing a loud noise. These properties are sometimes called **phenomenal properties**.

Human beings (obviously) have phenomenal properties — we experience all kinds of sensations.

Suppose that we were wholly physical things (as both the organism view and the brain view say). What would that imply about the nature of our phenomenal properties?

The following principle seems plausible:

Wholly physical things have only physical properties.

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The following principle seems plausible:

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But then it seems to follow from the fact that we have phenomenal properties that

If we are wholly physical things,
then phenomenal properties are
physical properties.

We'll now look at an argument that phenomenal properties are **not** physical properties — which, given the above, would show that we are not wholly physical things.

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First, let's consider a paradigmatically physical property, like the property of being water. What makes this a physical property?

Let's pretend for simplicity that protons, neutrons, and electrons are the most fundamental physical particles. Suppose now that we start with these basic building blocks and construct some molecules which contain two hydrogen atoms and one oxygen atom. Suppose now that we combine a quantity of these molecules in some container.

Would we have to do anything else to fill the container with water?

It seems clear that we would not. Once you arrange basic particles into H₂O molecules, you have made water. It would be **impossible** to have a quantity of H₂O without having water.

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Another way of putting this is that once you have fixed all of the facts about the fundamental particles, you have also fixed all of the facts about water.

Let's call the facts about the fundamental physical particles the **basic physical facts**. Then the idea is that the basic physical facts **necessitate** the water facts.

This seems like a pretty plausible definition of a physical property: a property is physical just in case the basic physical facts necessitate all of the facts about which things have the property.

Let's consider some other properties:

Weighing
10
pounds

Having a
temperature
of 90° F

Being a
gas

Being
bouncy

Being
smooth

These all seem to be physical properties, in our sense. It seems impossible to imagine two things which are alike with respect to their basic physical properties but differ with respect to one of these.

Indeed, at this point it might seem hard to see how **any** property could fail to be a physical property. It might seem that **all** of the facts about the universe are necessitated by the basic physical facts about the universe.

This thought suggests a certain sort of naturalistic, scientific view of reality. On this sort of view, we, and the world we inhabit, are fundamentally physical things. Ultimately everything about us, and the world we inhabit, can be explained in terms of the basic physical elements of which we are all composed.

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Water (once thought to be a primitive element) is just a certain combination of hydrogen and oxygen; heat (once thought to be an invisible fluid) is just molecular motion; life (once thought to be a primitive force) is just a complex series of biochemical reactions. Just so, phenomenal properties (which after all are studied by neuroscientists) will just turn out to be properties of the brain and nervous system.

This brings us to the central mystery of consciousness: phenomenal properties do not fit as neatly into this naturalistic worldview as one might expect.

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Consider the following thought experiment from David Chalmers:

“... it is conceivable that there be a system that is physically identical to a conscious being, but that lacks at least some of that being’s conscious states. Such a system might be a zombie: a system that is physically identical to a conscious being but that lacks consciousness entirely. ... These systems will look identical to a normal conscious being from the third-person perspective: in particular, their brain processes will be molecule-for-molecule identical with the original, and their behavior will be indistinguishable. But things will be different from the first-person point of view.”



This brings us to the central mystery of consciousness: phenomenal properties do not fit as neatly into this naturalistic worldview as one might expect.

We cannot conceive of a molecule-for-molecule duplicate of a basketball which is not spherical, or not rubber, or not bouncy — all of these properties are necessitated by the basic physical properties of the ball. But it seems that we can conceive of a molecule for molecule duplicate of you which lacks your phenomenal properties.

Such a being would be, in Chalmers' sense, a **zombie**.

Zombies are examples of things which are physical duplicates of conscious beings but which lack consciousness. It seems that we can also, as Chalmers points out, imagine examples of beings which are physical duplicates of conscious beings which have **different** phenomenal properties than the original beings.

One example here is the example of **spectrum inversion**.

Here's a representation of the different hues that we represent in visual experience:



Someone who is spectrum inverted relative to you would, when looking at an object, see the hue opposite on the circle to the one that you see.

So, the sort of experience you have when you look at a lime would be the sort of experience your invert would have when looking at a ripe tomato.

So, for example, imagine that you are having an experience which feels like this.

Then your invert's experience would feel like this.



But even though your experiences might feel different from the inside, many have thought that spectrum inversion might be undetectable. After all, if someone asks your invert what color bananas are, they'll say the same thing as you — 'yellow.' After all, they've been taught to use the word 'yellow' to apply to just the same things as you.

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More generally, many have thought that it is conceivable that your invert might be a molecule-for-molecule duplicate of you.

If so, examples of spectrum inversion, like the example of zombies, seems to show that it is conceivable that two molecule-for-molecule duplicates could differ in their phenomenal properties.

Here is a third kind of example. Imagine that in 10 years we have artificially intelligent robots capable of navigating the world with the proficiency of a human. We can then imagine wondering whether these robots had phenomenal properties.

It might well be hard to know. In that case, it seems that we would be in position to imagine both the scenario that that robot does have phenomenal properties, and that it does not. So we would again be imagining two scenarios which are physically alike but different with respect to phenomenal properties.

Notice, again, that we can't do this with other kinds of properties. Try to imagine the following scenarios:

two TV screens alike
with respect to the
arrangement and color
of their pixels but
which are showing
very different images

two cups which are
alike with respect to
the amount and
distribution of H₂O
particles but
which contain very
different quantities
of water

two plants which are
molecule-for-molecule
duplicates of each
other, but one is
alive and
the other is dead
(or: one is healthy
but the other is not)

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Phenomenal properties seem weirdly special in this respect. And
that gives us the resources to construct an argument.

It is conceivable that
two beings be
physically the same
but differ with
respect to their
phenomenal properties.

If a situation is
conceivable, it is
possible.

It is possible that
two beings be
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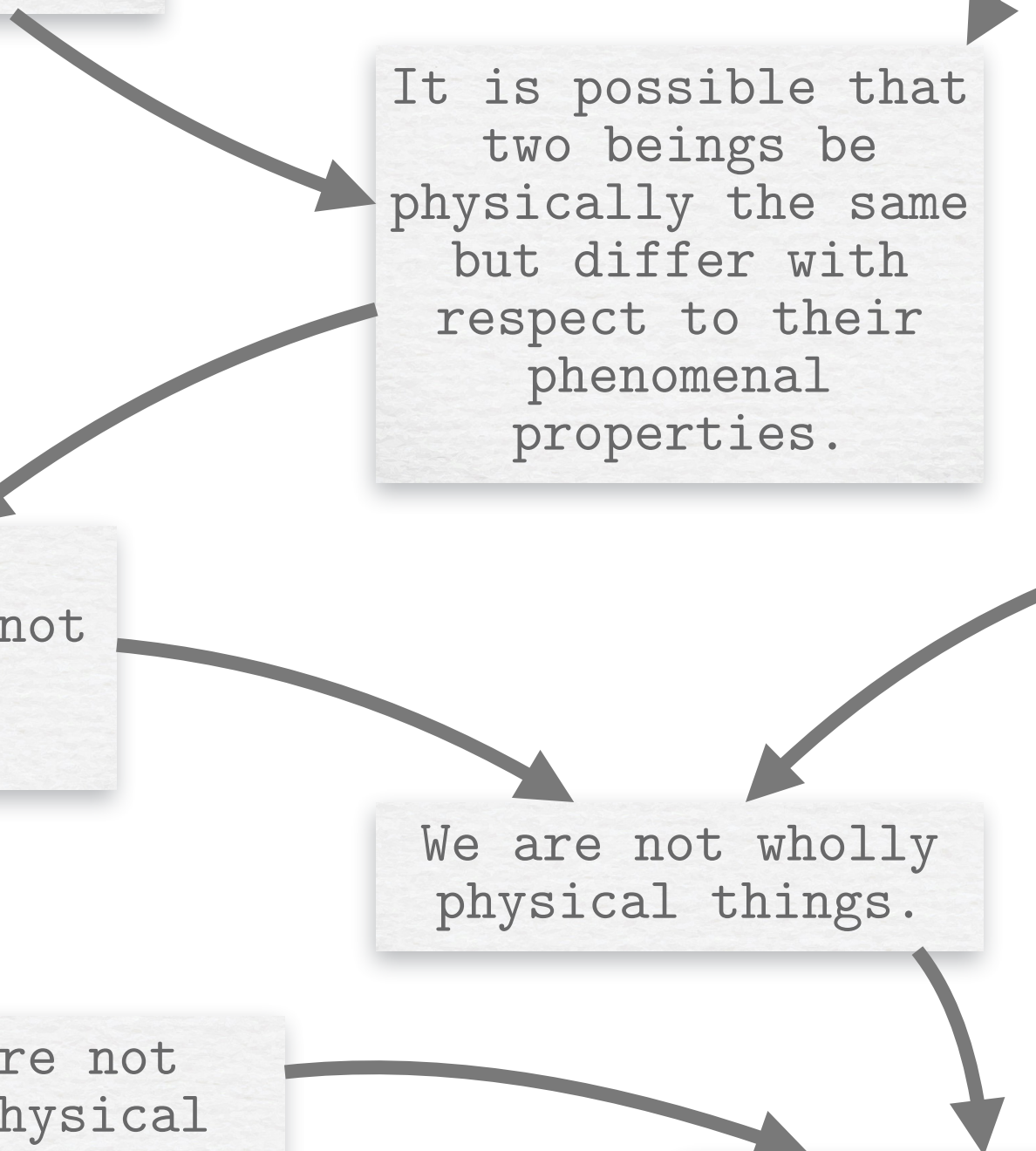
Phenomenal
properties are not
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If we are wholly
physical things,
then phenomenal
properties are
physical
properties.

We are not wholly
physical things.

If we are not
wholly physical
things then
immaterial souls
exist.

Immaterial souls
exist.



THE CONCEIVABILITY ARGUMENT

1. It is conceivable that two beings be physically the same but differ with respect to their phenomenal properties.
2. If a situation is conceivable, it is possible.
3. It is possible that two beings be physically the same but differ with respect to their phenomenal properties. (1,2)
4. Phenomenal properties are not physical properties. (3, definition of 'physical property')
5. If we are wholly physical things, then phenomenal properties are physical properties.
6. We are not wholly physical things. (4,5)
7. If we are not wholly physical things then immaterial souls exist.

C. Immaterial souls exist. (6,7)

If we are not wholly physical things, then presumably we are (at least in part) immaterial souls. So, if the conceivability argument is sound, there are immaterial souls. And if there are immaterial souls, it seems plausible that they would play a role in answering the survival question.

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Suppose that you don't believe in immaterial souls. How should you respond?

One option is to deny premise (2), and say that sometimes situations can be conceivable, but not genuinely possible.

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One option is to deny premise (2), and say that sometimes situations can be conceivable, but not genuinely possible.

Here is a possible counterexample to this premise:

The barber

Deep in the Indiana countryside, there's a small town; and in this town there's a barber. Some of the men in this small town - the industrious ones - shave themselves every morning. But others (the lazy ones) don't; and the barber shaves all of them. (There's no one else around who will do it.) Moreover, he (the barber's a man) never shaves any of the industrious ones - he never shaves any of the men that shave themselves.

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Can you clearly imagine this small town? Is it possible for there to be a town of this sort?

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Does the town's barber shave himself, or not?

No.

But then he does shave himself, because he shaves every man that does not shave himself.

Yes.

But then he doesn't, because he doesn't shave any man that shaves himself.

So if he shaves himself, then he doesn't, and if he doesn't, he does.

This is thus an example of a scenario which, at first glance, seems possible, but then turns out, on closer inspection to be impossible, because it contains a hidden contradiction. Might the someone who does not believe in immaterial souls plausibly say the same thing about the examples of zombies and spectrum inversion?

Maybe. But there are two residual challenges.

The first is just to say what this contradiction could be. It is easy enough to explain what the contradiction is in the story of the barber. But what is contradictory about the zombie or inversion or our AI robot scenarios?

The second is more subtle. And this is to explain why the scenarios seem conceivable in the first place. If phenomenal properties really are physical properties, why is it so easy to imagine cases in which there are phenomenal differences without physical differences? Why are phenomenal properties unlike, for example, density or shape or water or life in this way?

A second response would concede that phenomenal properties are not physical properties, but deny that this leads to a belief in immaterial souls.

One way to make this seem plausible is to note that plenty of things besides humans seem to have phenomenal properties. It is controversial exactly where to draw the line between conscious and unconscious organisms, but it seems very plausible that, e.g., frogs are conscious. So the conceivability argument would seem to show that frogs have immaterial souls.

Is this plausible? If not, does it make sense to say that we have non-physical properties despite not having any non-physical parts?

Let's turn now to a second, shorter argument in favor of immaterial souls.

Consider my body. It has many parts: my arms, my legs, etc. But it also has parts we don't have ready names for. For example, there is all of my body besides my right arm. And all of me besides my left big toe. And ...

This shows that there are in fact many overlapping physical things in your seat right now. By itself, that is arguably not especially puzzling.

There is at least one thing (hopefully) thinking in your seat right now. If there are no immaterial souls, then that thing is a material thing.

What would it take for a material thing to think? Presumably, if material things can think, thinking is just a matter of that material thing having a certain kind of complex physical organization. Maybe it would have to have some kind of complex information-processing features analogous to our brain. Let's call these the **thinking-relevant physical properties**,

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But note that many of the distinct physical things sitting in your seat right now have the thinking-relevant properties. For example, the object which is all of you other than your left thumb's fingernail would seem to.

So, if material things can think, there are a huge number of distinct thinking things in your seat right now.

But that is absurd. So, material things cannot think. Since you can think, you must be (at least in part) an immaterial soul.

But that is absurd. So, material things cannot think. Since you can think, you must be (at least in part) an immaterial soul.

THE MANY THINKERS ARGUMENT

1. If physical things can think, then any physical thing with the thinking-relevant properties can think.
2. There are many distinct things with the thinking-relevant properties in your seat right now.
3. If physical things can think, there are many distinct thinkers in your seat right now. (1,2)
4. There are not many distinct thinkers in your seat right now.
5. Physical things cannot think. (3,4)
6. You can think.
7. You are not a wholly physical thing. (5,6)
8. If we are not wholly physical things then immaterial souls exist.

C. Immaterial souls exist. (7,8)

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Could you deny premise (2)?

Maybe. But you really do seem to have lots of parts, and you do not seem to be identical to, e.g., your hand. What's the principled reason for making an exception for 'bigger' parts, like all of you other than your hand?

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Could you deny premise (4), and accept many thinkers?

Maybe. But what goes for thinking plausibly goes for sensations like pain as well.

Do we have a moral obligation to avoid causing pain to larger people, on the ground that they contain more parts with the pain-relevant properties, so that harming them causes more individuals to feel pain?

Let's turn now to the case **against** immaterial souls. We're going to talk about two types of arguments. The first is an argument against any view which says that phenomenal properties are not physical properties. It begins with a question:

Are there causal interactions between physical and phenomenal properties?

One answer is: Yes.
Physical properties can cause phenomenal properties, **and** phenomenal properties can cause physical properties.

interactionism

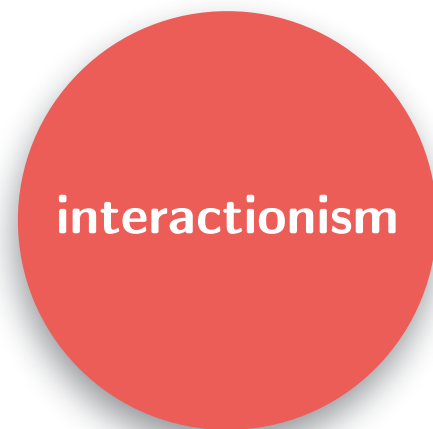
A second answer is: Yes.
Physical properties can cause phenomenal properties; **but** phenomenal properties cannot cause physical properties.

**epi-
phenomenalism**

A third answer is: No.
Physical and phenomenal properties cannot causally interact.

parallelism

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We can imagine a timeline of distinct, but apparently related, physical and phenomenal events.

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MG/DL

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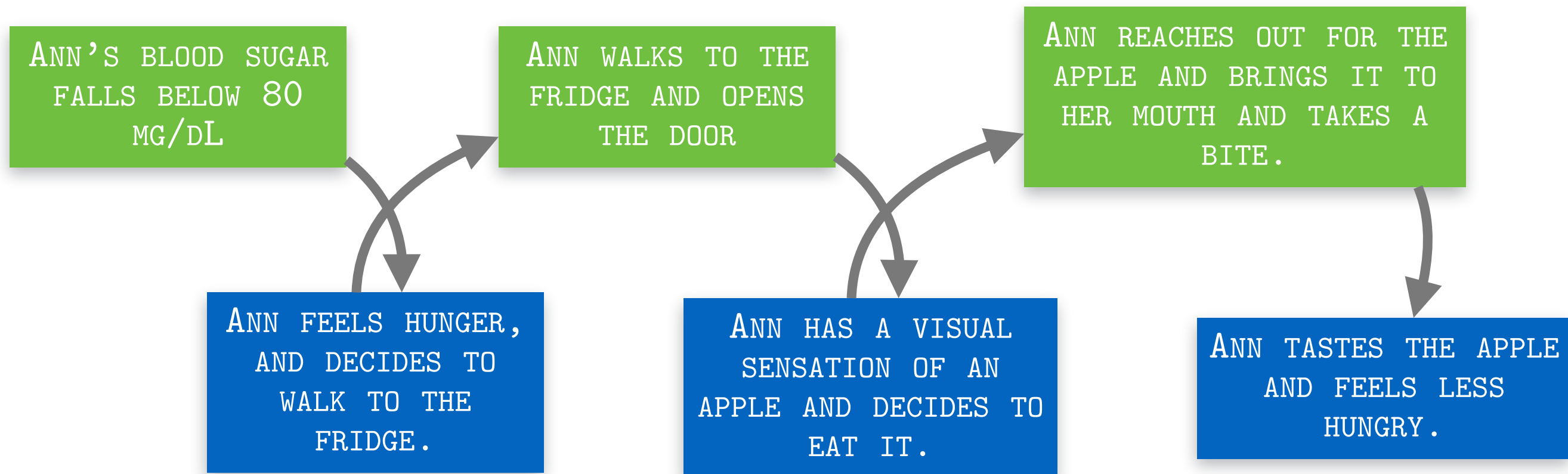
interactionism

epi-
phenomenalism

parallelism

We can imagine a timeline of distinct, but apparently related, physical and phenomenal events.

Using arrows to represent causal relations, we can diagram the intuitive causal relations between these events.

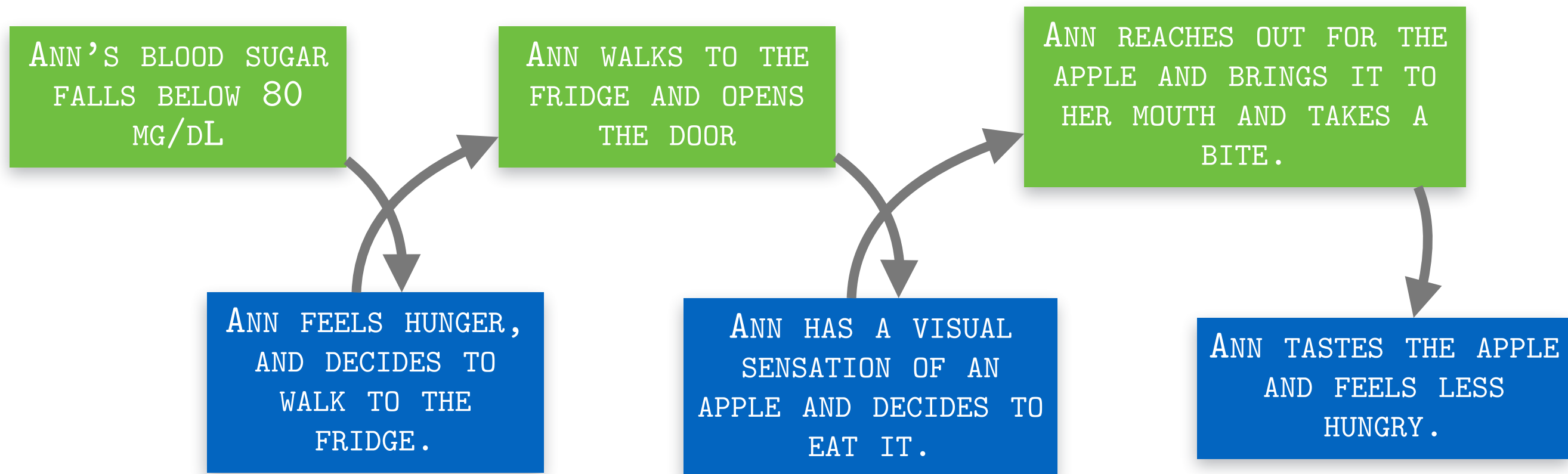


interactionism

epi-
phenomenalism

parallelism

According to the interactionist, this intuitive picture gets things just right.
Physical events cause phenomenal events, and vice versa.



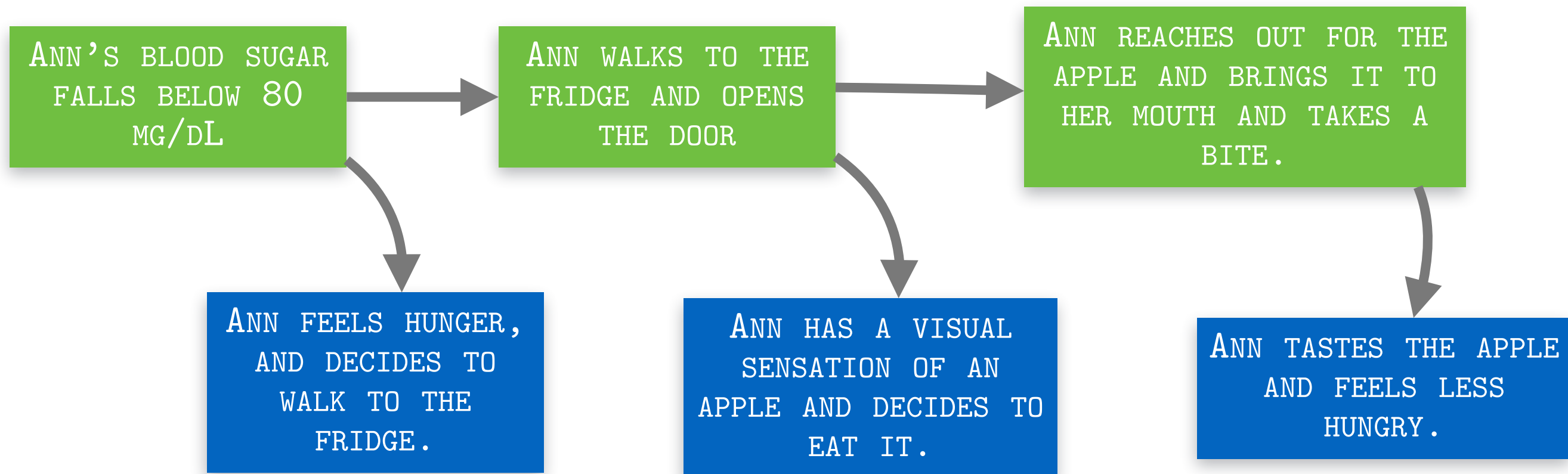
interactionism

epi-
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parallelism

According to the epiphenomenalist, things look very different.

Here we have physical events causing phenomenal events and subsequent physical events, but no mental-to-physical causation. Mental events are like a scoreboard which record but do not affect physical happenings.



interactionism

epi-
phenomenalism

parallelism

According to the parallelist, things look very different again.

The physical and mental worlds are two parallel chains of causation, with neither affecting the other.

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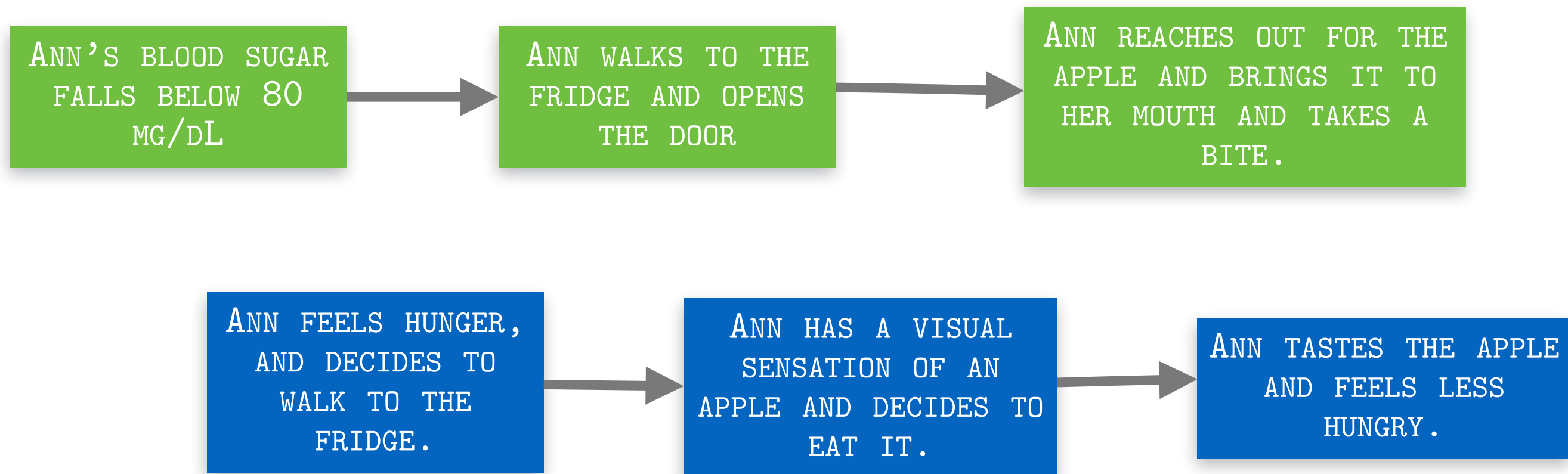
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parallelism

Each of these views has its own strengths and weaknesses.

Let's start with the parallelist. This looks like the craziest of the three views -- why would anyone hold it?

One reason for taking parallelism seriously is that causal connections between the physical and mental realms can look very puzzling.



parallelism

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Let's start with the parallelist. This looks like the craziest of the three views -- why would anyone hold it?

One reason for taking parallelism seriously is that causal connections between the physical and mental realms can look very puzzling.

One historically very important argument that there can be no causal connections of this kind was given by Elisabeth of Bohemia, a 17th century German philosopher.



“it seems every determination of movement happens from the impulsion of a thing moved, according to the manner in which it is pushed by that which moves it ... Contact is required for [this]. ... contact seems to me incompatible with the idea of an immaterial thing.”

parallelism

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Elisabeth here is considering a special case of causation: putting something in motion. For something to push something else, it seems that the two things must be in contact; and for two things to be in contact, both must occupy space (since being in contact is just a matter of occupying adjacent spaces). Since immaterial souls don't occupy space, it seems that they can't set things in motion — so, for example, my mind's desire for coffee can't be what sends my body down the hallway in search of some.

parallelism



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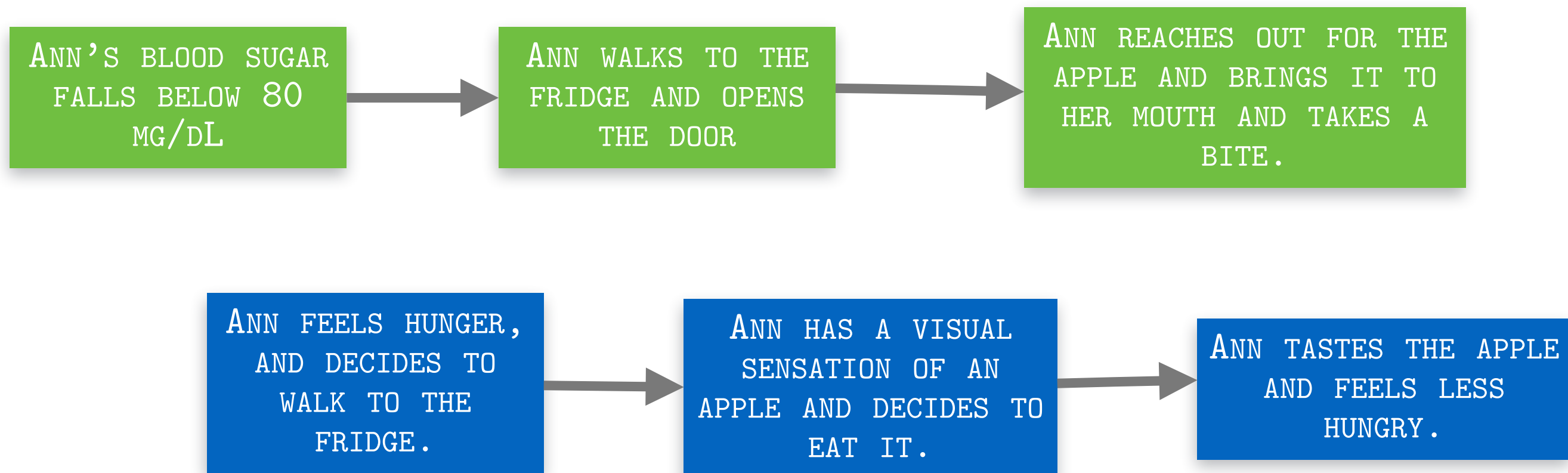
While ingenious, this argument looks less strong in the context of contemporary physics than in the context of the physics of Elisabeth’s day. Consider the example of gravity. The earth interacts with the moon via its gravitational force. But this interaction does not require contact — so why, in general, should we think that contact is required for causal interaction?

Even if this is a successful reply to Elisabeth, many contemporary philosophers have thought that she was on to something, and that there is something suspicious about causal connections between distinct mental and physical properties. We’ll see why when we look at the arguments against the interactionist and epiphenomenalist.

parallelism

There are two main lines of argument against the parallelist. This first is simple. It posits a massive coincidence between the physical and mental realms. On this view, mental events reliably correspond to physical events, but there are no causal connections at all between them. What could explain this?

For this reason, virtually all defenders of parallelism have been theists, who hold that God arranged the world so that there was a harmony between the physical and mental orders. But some have wondered whether God wasn't thereby creating an illusion of causal connection between the mental and physical.

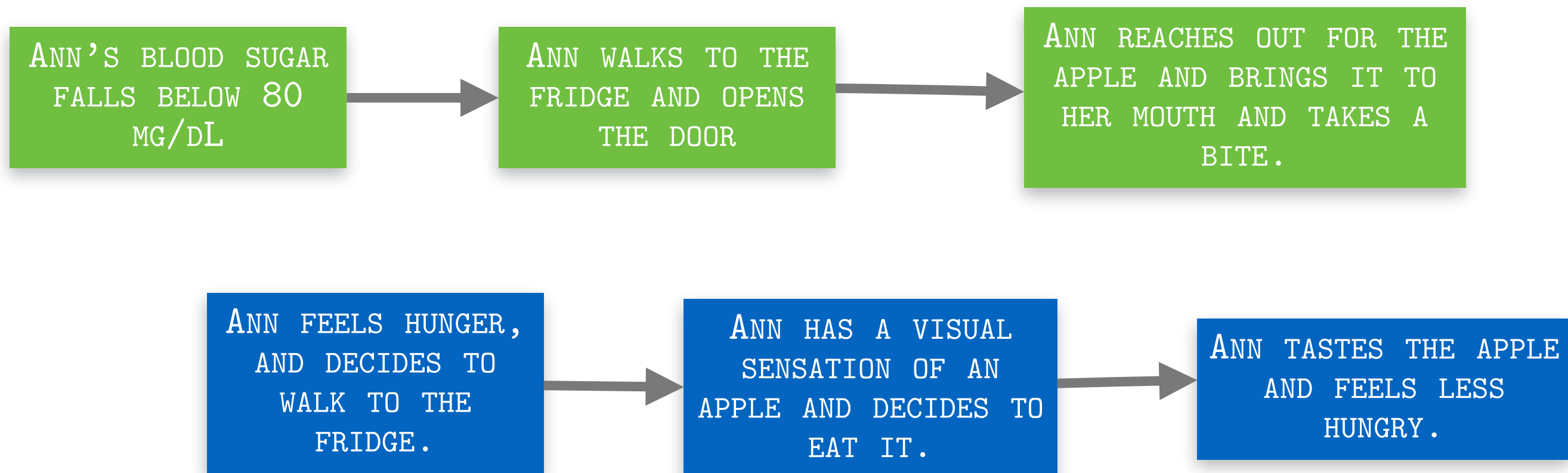


parallelism

A second argument is also simple. Once we think that there are no causal connections between the physical and mental worlds at all, why should we keep believing in a physical world at all?

This thought puts some pressure on the parallelist to become an **idealist**, who denies that there is any physical world at all.

Here is what our causal chain looks like, according to the idealist.



parallelism

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Here is what our causal chain looks like, according to the idealist.

There are no fridges, or doors, or apples, or walking -- just experiences as if there were such things. The fact that parallelism seems to lead to this sort of idealist view seems to many to be a reason to reject it.

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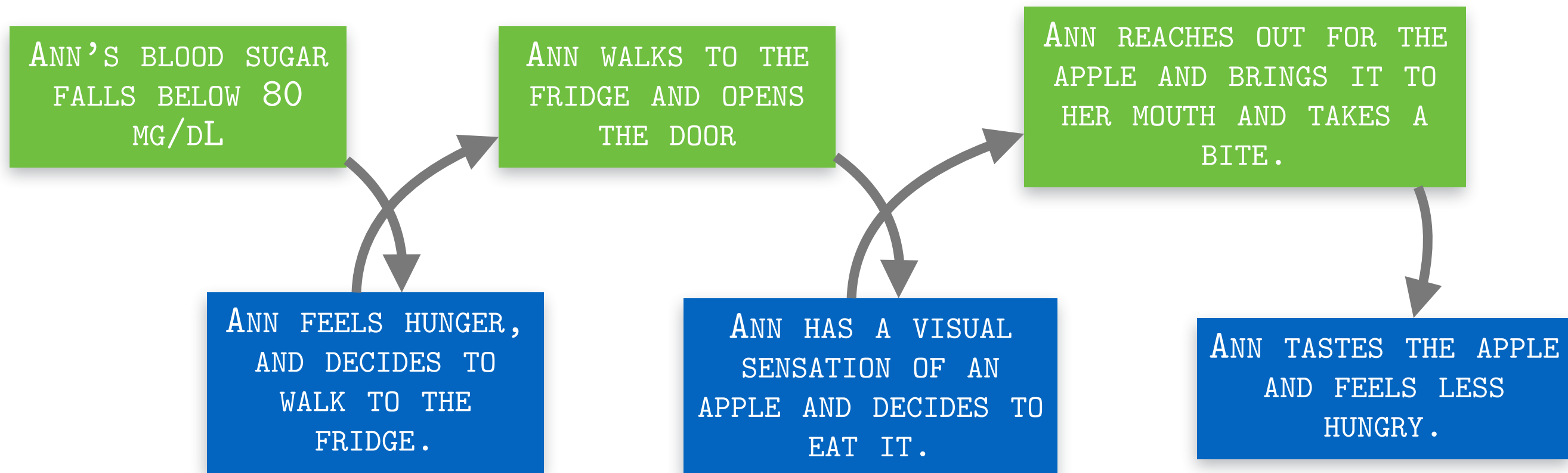
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interactionism

Most philosophers who have accepted the distinctness of phenomenal and physical properties have not been parallelists. Many have instead been interactionists. who can accept that the causal structure of reality is much as we take it to be.

But interactionist brings with it a puzzle. It seems to show that the view of the physical world that we get from modern physics is radically **incomplete**.

According to contemporary physics, there are four fundamental forces: gravity, electromagnetism, and the strong and weak nuclear forces.

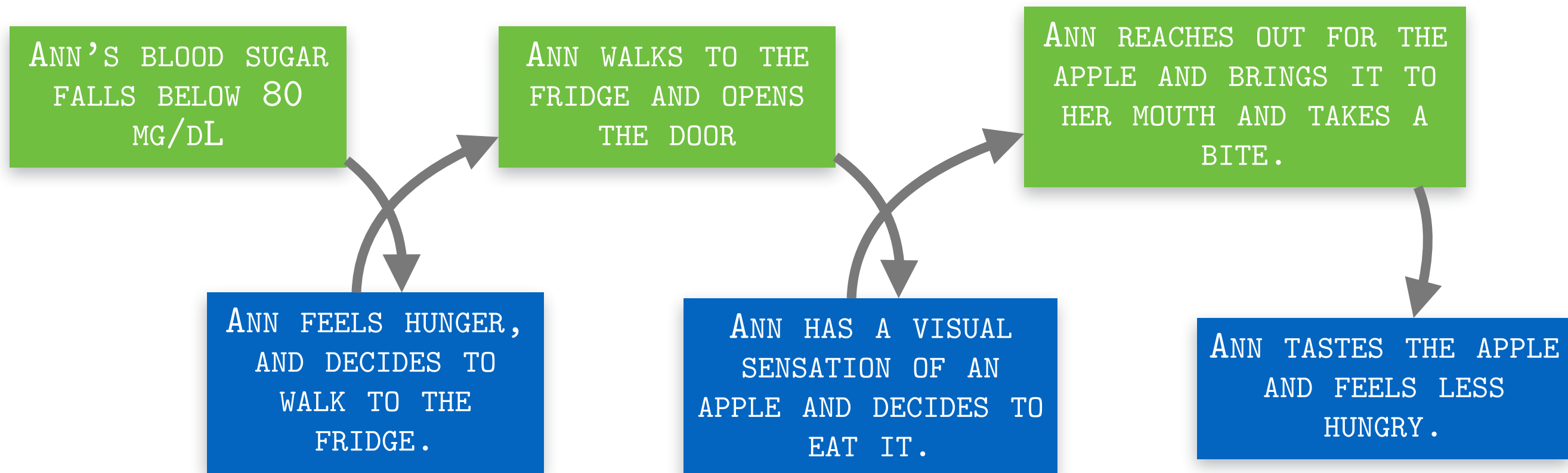


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According to contemporary physics, there are four fundamental forces: gravity, electromagnetism, and the strong and weak nuclear forces.

To say that these are fundamental is to say that they cannot be explained in more basic terms. To say that there are just four is to say that all interactions between physical things can be explained in terms of just these forces.

But consider Ann's act of walking to the fridge. If interactionism is true, this event is a counterexample to this general claim.



interactionism

According to contemporary physics, there are four fundamental forces: gravity, electromagnetism, and the strong and weak nuclear forces.

To say that these are fundamental is to say that they cannot be explained in more basic terms. To say that there are just four is to say that all interactions between physical things can be explained in terms of just these forces.

But consider Ann's act of walking to the fridge. If interactionism is true, this event is a counterexample to this general claim.

If interactionism is true, such exceptions are happening all of the time.

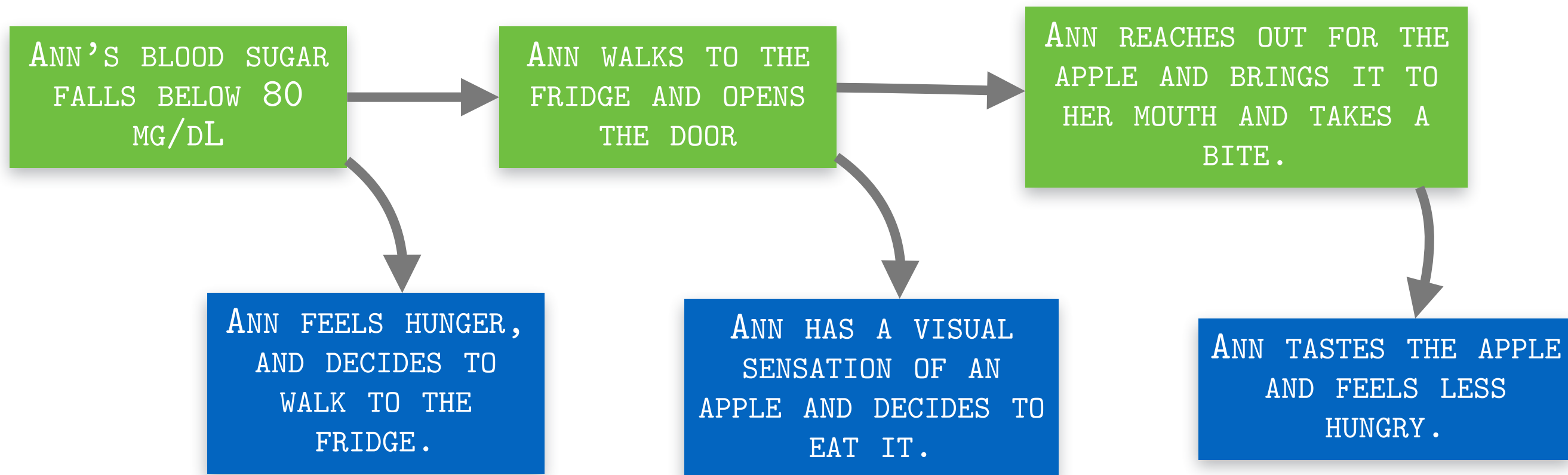
Imagine being a physicist in the universe of *Star Wars*, in which people can mentally make objects move by use of 'the force.' If you wanted a complete theory of the movement of physical objects, you could not stop with gravity, electromagnetism, and the strong and weak nuclear forces. You would have to posit a fifth fundamental **mental** force.

If interactionism is true, our world is in certain key respects similar to the universe of *Star Wars* in this way. This would be surprising!

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This might push one towards the initially surprising epiphenomenalist position. Unlike the parallelist, the epiphenomenalist does not think of the physical and mental realms as entirely disconnected. And unlike the interactionist, the epiphenomenalist does not have to think that physics must be supplemented with an additional mental 'force.'

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But epiphenomenalism too leads to a puzzle.

Suppose that I ask you how you are feeling, and you say 'I am feeling cold.' The event of you saying that is a physical event. It is a report of one of your phenomenal properties. Since (according to the epiphenomenalist) phenomenal properties never cause physical events, your utterance of 'I am cold' was not caused (even indirectly) by your feeling cold.

But that is deeply weird. Ordinarily when we report on things we do so on the basis of a causal interaction with them. If we try to describe things with which we have no causal contact it seems like we can only describe them correctly by being lucky. So it seems like we can only correctly describe our own conscious states by luck. But that seems crazy.

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The puzzle is, in a weird way, the reverse of the puzzle we discussed for the parallelist. The parallelist holds that the physical world is entirely causally separate from the mental world. That raised the question: why believe in a physical world at all?

The epiphenomenalist holds that the phenomenal world has no causal influence on our reports about our own consciousness. This raises the question: why believe in consciousness at all? We would, after all, be saying just the same thing things about our conscious experience even if we were not conscious at all.



interactionism

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phenomenalism**

parallelism

The conceivability argument, in its different forms, is a powerful challenge to the idea that consciousness can be smoothly assimilated into a worldview which holds that everything is, ultimately, physical.

But if one rejects that worldview, and holds that phenomenal properties are not physical properties, one faces the question of how the physical and phenomenal are related. And our discussion so far shows that this is a tough question to answer.

Let's turn to a second kind of argument against soul-based survival theories: **swapping arguments**. We already saw an example of these in Locke's argument against

Consider the following example.

Psychology-swapping

Ferdinand is a combination of a soul and a body. Suppose that Ferdinand suffers an accident which entirely changes his psychology. He has none of his former memories, and none of his former personality traits. He used to be very selfish; he's now very generous. He used to be best friends with Jane; now he finds Jane annoying, and prefers to spend time with Maria.

Let's call Ferdinand before the accident "Ferdinand-" and Ferdinand after the accident "Ferdinand+".

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Let's call Ferdinand before the accident "Ferdinand-" and Ferdinand after the accident "Ferdinand+".

Suppose that Ferdinand- used to occasionally take some cash from your wallet. Ferdinand+ would never do this. Would you be right to blame Ferdinand+ for the actions of Ferdinand-?

It seems plausible that you would not blame Ferdinand+ for these actions. Remember: he has complete amnesia, and his behavior and attitudes now are entirely different.

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But if you would not hold Ferdinand+ responsible for the actions of Ferdinand-, that suggests that you are treating Ferdinand+ as a different person than Ferdinand-.

But if they are different people, it looks like soul survival and $M + S$ are incorrect. For there is no obvious reason why the numerically same soul could not be attached to Ferdinand's body throughout this process.

Call this the **psychology-swapping argument** against the view that survival is based on the soul.

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THE PSYCHOLOGY-SWAPPING ARGUMENT

1. You should not hold Ferdinand+ responsible for the actions of Ferdinand-.
2. If you should not hold A responsible for any of the same actions as B, then A and B are different people.
3. Ferdinand+ is not the same person as Ferdinand-. (1,2)
4. It is possible that Ferdinand+ and Ferdinand- have the same soul and the same body.

C. Soul survival, materialist survival, and M+S are false. (3,4)

This argument relies on the idea that sufficient differences in psychology are enough to make for a difference in personal identity. Note that while this also rules out M+S, it does not rule out P+S.

Another 'swapping' argument attempts to show that any answer to the survival question that involves immaterial souls is false.

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Another 'swapping' argument attempts to show that any answer to the survival question that involves immaterial souls is false.

Let's suppose that your roommate is (either wholly or in part) an immaterial soul.

Here is something that seems possible: last night, the soul connected to your roommate's body could have been swapped out for a different one which has exactly the same apparent memories and personality.

You would, it seems, have no way of telling whether this happened. So you have no evidence that it did not happen. So, you do not know whether you have the same roommate as you did yesterday. But of course you do know this; so soul theories must be false.

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More dramatically, the soul attached to your own body could have been swapped out last night (or one second ago). It seems that you would have no way of knowing whether this happened. After all, the new soul (which you are) could have been given the same personality and apparent memories as the old soul.

Does this suggest that something is wrong with answers to the survival question which involve immaterial souls?